ARTIST REFERENCE

Tattoo Artist Cheat Sheet

Right needle, right depth, clean lines and a traceable ink lot.

Needle groupings

CODE	GROUPING	BEST FOR	WATCH FOR
RL	Round liner	Outlines, lettering, detail	1RL is single needle. Tight = crisper.
RS	Round shader	Bold lines, small shaded areas	Looser cluster. Don't overwork.
M1	Magnum (weaved)	Shading and color fill, big areas	Two staggered rows. Corners can scar.
CM	Curved magnum	Smooth blends, soft gradients	Also RM. Gentler on the skin.
BP	Bugpin · taper	Fine lines, soft shading	#10 (0.30 mm) needles; finer flow.
F	Flat	Geometric fill, crisp edges	One straight row. Keep the angle.

Line, shade & pack

TECHNIQUE	HAND AND PASSES	GOAL · COMMON MISTAKE
Lining	Steady, one confident pass	Solid line at even depth. Too deep blows out; too shallow skips.
Shading	Light layers, whip or pendulum	Smooth gradients. Overworking scars and slows healing.
Color packing	Small, slow overlapping circles	Full saturation. Stop when skin turns shiny and puffy.

Placement: pain level and risk

●●○○○	●●●○○	●●●○○	●●●●●	●●●●●	●●●●○	●●●●○
Outer arm	**Forearm**	**Thigh**	**Ribs**	**Sternum**	**Hands · fingers**	**Feet · ankles**
Easy starter	Inner side thin	Inner side thin	Stretch firmly	Bony, sensitive	Fades fast	Blowout, fading

Wrap options compared

WRAP	WEAR TIME	PROS · WATCH FOR
Plastic wrap	[2–5] hours	Cheap and familiar. Not breathable; off the same day.
Non-stick pad	[2–5] hours	Absorbs fluid. Can stick if left on too long.
Second-skin film	8–24 h, then up to [6] days	Fewer washes. Ask about adhesive allergy; never over 7 days total.

SKIN & DEPTH

- **Depth:** ink sits in the upper dermis, about [1–2] mm.
- Thin or older skin: lighter hand, fewer passes.
- Keloid history: small test area first.
- Scars: wait until fully mature, about [12] months.
- Moles: work around them, never over.
- Stretchy areas: stretch firmly and evenly.

INK STORAGE & RECALLS

- **Log brand, color, lot # and expiry** per client.
- Store sealed, cool and dark; date when opened.
- Discard expired ink. Check FDA recalls [monthly].
- Single-use caps; never pour ink back.
- EU/UK: REACH-compliant inks with batch number.
- Recall? Pull the lot and check client records.

Every time. Follow maker instructions and health department rules. Depths are a guide; adjust to each client.